

protégés of Saint-Saëns, whose music Satie loathed.

Nevertheless, he studied diligently for five years, paying his way with the earnings from his cabaret work.

This period allowed him to mature as a composer and to consolidate his ideas: he moved away from the light, evocative piano pieces for which he was best known, and formulated what can be regarded as a Modernist musical philosophy, rejecting the overblown self-indulgence and sentimentality he associated with the late 19th century. Sometimes ironic, sometimes satirical or parodistic of classical ideas, he placed emphasis on clarity and simplicity.



AT THE MOULIN ROUGE, THE DANCE, 1889–1890

Toulouse-Lautrec's painting captures the atmosphere of Montmartre's decadent cabaret scene, in which Satie thrived.

Cryptic compositions

With his studies at the Schola Cantorum complete, Satie set about composing with renewed confidence. He published a set of piano